Toward a classical piano house style

Three open-source engines. Four treatments. Two identical original piano studies.

What the Henle reference suggests

The inspected Chopin Nocturnes HN 185 pages 7-8 suggest a strong contrast between dark noteheads and fine staff lines, tapered slurs, compact rhythmic groups, discreet fingerings, and deliberate separation of the two hands. These are visual observations, not measured Henle specifications. Henle says its custom music fonts reproduce historical engraving tools and are not commercially available.

How to compare these pages

Each treatment uses the same notes, voices, beams, slur endpoints, dynamics, and line breaks. Staff height is 7 mm and the staff line width is 197 mm, on 235 x 310 mm pages. Scores remain vector artwork at native scale. Compare the melody slurs, accompaniment beams, fingering weight, and space between the hands. Print at actual size; screen antialiasing can change perceived weight.

The four treatments

A - LilyPond baseline: default engraving with common page geometry.
B - LilyPond classical: lighter staff lines, restrained text and fingerings, altered spacing, beam weight, and slur geometry.
C - MuseScore / Leland: a reusable style preset and an editable graphical score.
D - Verovio / Leipzig: a programmable SVG/MEI route with an alternative glyph family.

Initial assessment

B is my preferred starting point for a reproducible engraving pipeline; C is a strong alternative if its rounder slurs and steadier beams appeal more. D is valuable for browser previews and font exploration. These are provisional visual judgments. The samples do not establish a winner for complex piano repertoire.

Framework and next test

Scan recognition -> corrected MusicXML -> shared house style -> score-specific refinements -> vector PDF -> visual proof. This prototype implements the engraving comparison, not scan recognition. Next, use a longer passage with tuplets, grace notes, cross-staff beams, pedal changes, and page turns before choosing production defaults.

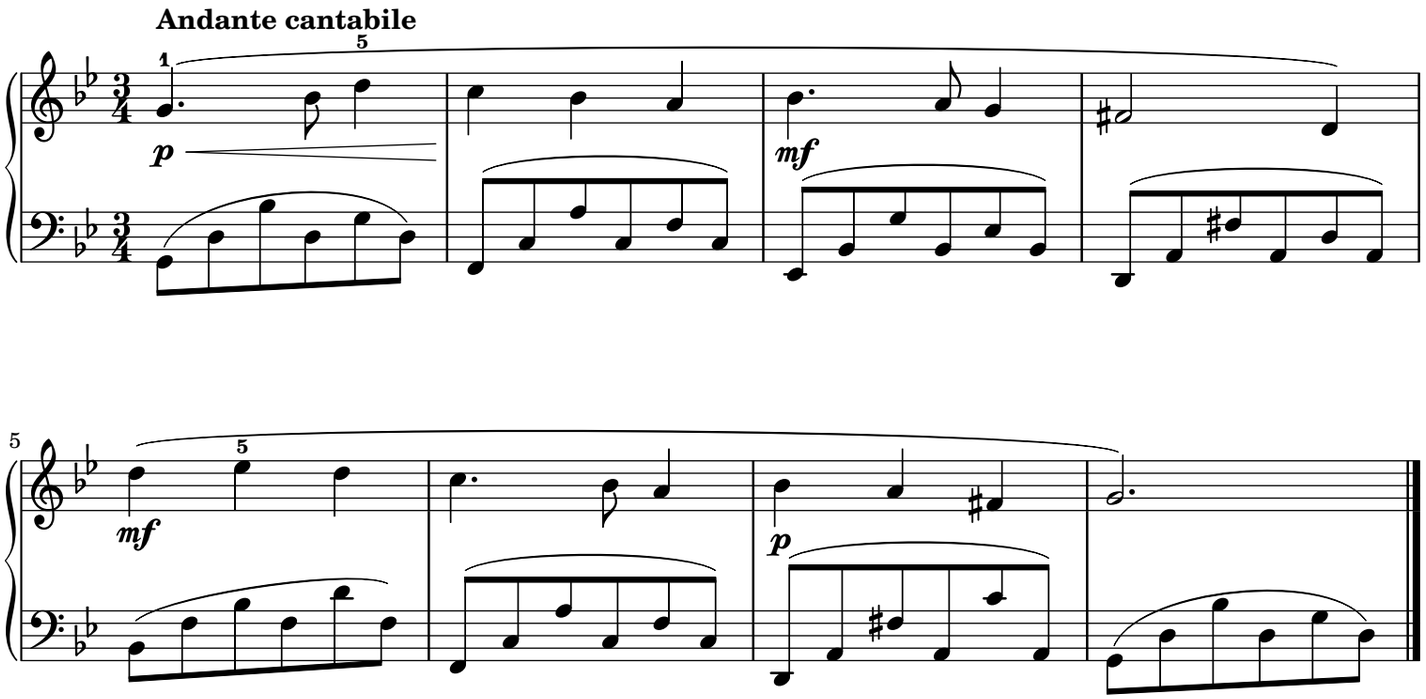
Primary references

Henle: Nocturnes HN 185 and Look inside previews
Henle: engraving fonts and production methods
LilyPond: spacing controls
MuseScore: command line export
Verovio: renderer options

A / LilyPond baseline

Emmentaler music font; default engraving. Common scale, margins, and breaks only.

I. Cantabile study / 8 bars in G minor



II. Figuration study / 4 bars in C major



B / LilyPond classical

Emmentaler + Nimbus Roman. Adjusted line weight, spacing, slurs, and fingerings.

I. Cantabile study / 8 bars in G minor



II. Figuration study / 4 bars in C major



C / MuseScore Studio

Leland + Nimbus Roman. Styled command line export; graphical editing available.

I. Cantabile study / 8 bars in G minor



II. Figuration study / 4 bars in C major



D / Verovio

Leipzig music font. Explicit import notation, encoded line breaks, and full-width final systems.

I. Cantabile study / 8 bars in G minor



II. Figuration study / 4 bars in C major

